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White Bear Boxing instructor reflects on 70 years in the sport

by Aaron Hagstrom/Contributing Writer
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Yanez, third from right in the middle row, in 1944 with some of his fellow Air Force boxers in Leicester, England. — Submitted photo

WHITE BEAR LAKE — Ninety-two-year-old retired boxing trainer Emmett Yanez — a St. Paul native — has been a testament of dedication to young people for nearly 70 years.

Since starting work at the White Bear Lake Boxing Club 12 years ago, Yanez has trained many successful boxers including a handful of Upper Midwest champs and Saint Paul Golden Gloves. Most recently he coached Robert Brant to the National Golden Gloves; Brant is now training for the 2012 London Olympics.

As a teenager in St. Paul during the Depression era, Yanez was a breadwinner for his large Catholic family, and helped support them by boxing and by laboring in the beet fields alongside his father. In 1939, Yanez won the Saint Paul Golden Gloves at only age 17—a big feat for a young man.

“My parents and mentors were strict, but they taught me self-respect and how to work hard, which has made me a success today,” Yanez asserted.

In 1940, Yanez joined the 82nd Airborne and soon found his values put to the test in some of the thickest fighting of the war. Jumping into Holland during Operation Market Garden — the largest airborne drop in history — he served in the dangerous position of airborne scout. During the operation his regiment, the 504th, was responsible for capturing the Graves Bridge, one of the few bridges captured intact.

“It was a miracle that I even survived the war,” he said. “Sometimes you couldn’t make yourself flat enough to dodge what was coming at you.”

Yanez attributes his survival not only to miracles, but also to his boxing skills.

“You find yourself in a lot of situations when you have to think real fast to survive, and boxing is all about quick thinking,” he said.

To keep in training while in the service, he joined the 504th regimental boxing team. While on R&R in Leicester, England, his team sparred with British paratroopers. ‘We beat the hell out of them,” he laughed.

Back from the war, Yanez taught at Clancy’s Gym and even opened his own Mexican-American gym before accepting a position at the White Bear Lake Boxing Club.

“It makes you feel good when you start kids on the right road,” he said, “I teach them dedication, and the first thing I tell them is they are wasting my time if they don’t want to work hard.”

His favorite boxer is Willie Pep, an American featherweight known for his tenacity in the fight. “He took on all-comers. It didn’t matter whether they were lightweight or heavyweight,” he said.

Yanez retains good relationships with many students who are grateful for his coaching.

“They come around and visit me with their wives,” he said. “ Others think they did it on their own.”

He has striven to pass on his lifestyle of dedication to his children. He pointed at a photograph of a young man in olive drab, manning the turret of a naval gunboat. “My son Ronnie went to Vietnam and did his duty; he was lucky to survive and come back.” Ronnie is now a real estate agent in California.

Yanez said he attributes the nervous strain of Ronnie’s tour in Vietnam to the untimely death of his first wife Nataline soon afterwards. But his faith allowed him to see purpose even in her death. Today, he is happily married to his second wife. “I’m lucky to have a wife who can carry on the work of my first wife,” he said.

“I’ve enjoyed my life — good or bad — and just hope I have made others happy.”

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